

If you see any unusual symptoms in farmed or wild aquatic animals, including unusual fish deaths, report it to the Emergency Animal Disease Hotline on 1800 675 888.

Risks to aquatic animal health come from a variety of sources, including:

- aquarium fish, also known as ornamental fish
- bait and berley
- seafood
- fishing and boating equipment.

The main risks associated with these sources are the spread of pests and diseases to new areas. Some live species have the potential to become pests and are difficult to eradicate.

You can play a vital role in protecting Australia's aquatic animal health. This page provides information on simple practices the public can use to protect the health of Australia's aquatic animals.

Aquarium Fish

Like all animals, aquarium fish can carry and transmit aquatic animal diseases. These diseases pose a risk to our wild fisheries, waterways and aquaculture industries if they escaped from aquariums into the environment. The below provides information and advice on how responsible fish owners can help prevent ornamental fish disease outbreaks.

What you can do to prevent the spread of disease

Maintain a healthy aquarium

- Buy healthy fish to avoid introducing serious diseases to your aquarium.
- Get advice from your veterinarian or pet retailer on how to maintain a healthy aquarium.
- If you suspect a serious disease in your aquarium fish, contact your local veterinarian or state laboratory. Signs to look for include:
 - abnormal swimming behaviours
 - bloated stomach
 - bulging eyes
 - loss of appetite
 - loss of bright colours
 - loss of buoyancy control
 - skin ulcers and eroded fins.

Dispose of fish and water appropriately

- Never release or dispose of aquarium fish in waterways. This includes stormwater drains. Both live and dead fish have the potential to spread diseases.
- Return unwanted fish to your local pet store (most pet shops will take healthy fish)

- Humanely euthanase sick fish and dispose of in municipal waste.
- Ensure outdoor ponds or aquariums cannot overflow into local waterways or stormwater drains.
- Always dispose of aquarium water appropriately (e.g., down a household sink or in a suitable garden bed).
 - do not dispose of tank water in local waterways or down stormwater drains.
 - do not dispose of tank water in areas where it can flow into local waterways.
 - if disease is suspected in the aquarium only dispose of water down a household sink.

Bait and berley

Like animals, the movement of bait and berley products within Australia has the potential to introduce or spread aquatic animal diseases.

The [National Policy Guidelines for Translocation of Domestic Bait and Berley](#) provide a national framework for bait translocation policies in Australian states and territories to address identified disease risks. The guidelines provide information on:

- bait and berley products
- the nature of disease risks
- principles for policy development
- possible instruments for managing identified risks
- a staged approach for policy development.

Ensure you are familiar with and follow regulations on the use of bait and berley in your state or territory.

What you can do to prevent the spread of disease

Wild caught bait

- If you catch your own bait, use it only in the water body it came from.
- Never release live bait into a water body other than the one in which it was caught.

Store bought bait

- Never use seafood intended for human consumption as bait.
- see the [Prawn imports and biosecurity page](#) for further information.
- Only buy products to use as bait that are being sold as bait (e.g., from retail outlets such as fishing or bait stores).

Seafood

Like animals, seafood products intended for human consumption, have the potential to carry and transmit aquatic animal diseases.

What you can do to prevent the spread of disease

- Never dispose of seafood or seafood waste (e.g., prawn heads, oyster shells, fish heads, bones, etc.) in waterways, stormwater drains or areas where they can enter local waterways.
- Always dispose of unwanted seafood or seafood waste in the municipal waste.

Fishing and boating equipment

Fishing and boating equipment can transmit aquatic animal diseases and pests. Follow any biosecurity guidelines or regulations directed at fishers and boaters in your state or territory.

What you can do to prevent the spread of disease

Check and drain

- Dislodge any plants and animals from your equipment, including waders, boots, and nets, or clothing, such as wetsuits, so you don't move them to other waterways.
- Drain water from boats and equipment. Drain water back into the waterway it came from. Do not dispose of it in a different waterway or down stormwater drains.

Rinse, wash, dry

- Rinse boats and equipment, including waders, boots, and nets with fresh water, without letting it drain into any waterways.
- Wash boats and equipment with detergent, rinse with tap water and dry completely before moving to another waterway.
- Launder clothing, such as wetsuits, appropriately before wearing in a different waterway.

Other risks to aquatic animal health

Infectious diseases are just one source of risk to aquatic animal health in Australia. Other risks include environmental risks and marine pests. For more information on these risks visit:

For further information contact the Aquatic Pest and Health Policy section at: aah@aff.gov.au.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/animal/aquatic/how-you-can-protect-aquatic-animal-health>